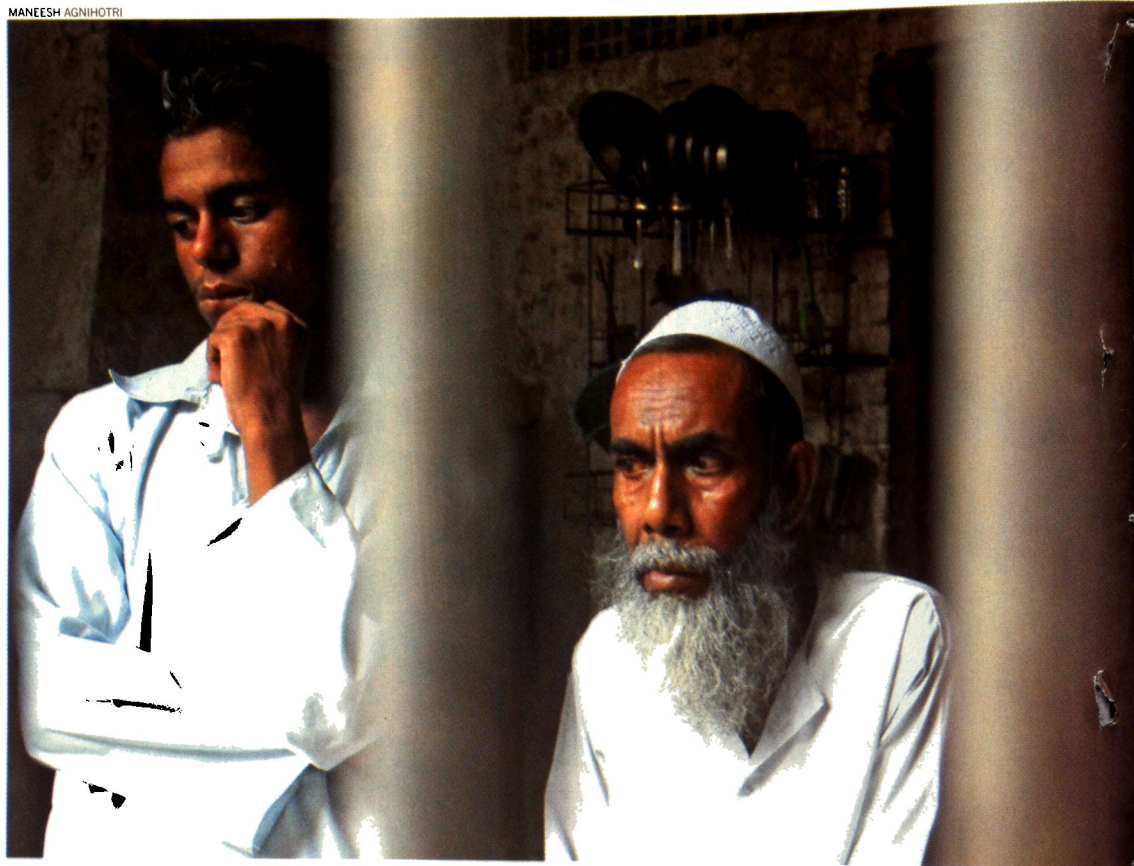


MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



WITHOUT HOPE: Abu Bakar (centre), father of the arrested terrorist Abu Bashir, with his other sons

try seems to be travel agency. At Ahbab Travels, run by Kalim Jamai and his cousin, the walls are colonised by the names of Saraimir's most favoured airlines: Oman Air, Pakistan International, Gulf Air, Saudi Arabian Airlines, Qatar Airways, Kuwait Airways... Jamai, though a businessman, is not proud of the new brand value of Azamgarh. He feels ashamed—and angry, because those students of Jamia from his town are innocent. "All these bomb blasts are because of Gujarat and Narendra Modi. Don't blame those boys."

The boys of Saraimir and the adjoining village of Sanjarpur, killed or arrested elsewhere in India, will never be blamed by Jamai. And all the boys don't go to Jamia or other universities. Their adolescence is shaped by the exclusive walls of

madrasas (and there are about 150 registered ones in Azamgarh) where their only friends are Muslims and the world is absolutely Quaranic and most of them end up in the Gulf countries as labourers. That means good business for travel agents like Kalim. That means, according to the police, a multi-crore business for the faceless hawala operators as well. Some boys, the adventurous ones like Salem, seek a career in the Mumbai underworld. And some are swayed by the jihadi chic. But angry Azamgarhis refuse to believe that their children can ever be the foot soldiers of god's army. They are only keeping the migratory tradition of Azamgarh (before the Gulf, the destinations were countries like Burma, Malaysia and Singapore) alive. And in the process

“ Indian Mujahideen is an IB creation to demonise Muslim community. All Muslims should join SIMI. ”

SHAHID BADR, FORMER SIMI LEADER

